

Exclamations

Almost any type of sentence can be made into an exclamation. The most common types of exclamations are emotional statements, commands, and interjections.

Exclamation points are **rarely** used in **names**, but the name of the Canadian town of **Saint-Louis-du-Ha! Ha!** officially has two.

Statements

A statement, which normally ends in a period, can be made into an exclamation if it conveys an emotion. An emotional statement ends with an exclamation point instead of a period.

There's a mouse
in the kitchen!

Commands

Exclamation points are often used in commands, especially when they are direct orders rather than polite requests.

Be quiet and don't
move suddenly!

Interjections

Interjections—words usually exclaimed in urgency or surprise—are some of the most common types of exclamations. Interjections are often single words rather than sentences.

Help!

Emphasis

Exclamation points are often placed next to interruptions within parentheses or dashes to add emphasis to an interruption. Never use an exclamation point alongside a question mark.

Our hero (thankfully!)
arrived just in time.

The interruption uses an exclamation point to emphasize how grateful the speaker was.



• **One exclamation point** has a greater impact than several, so using **more than one** exclamation point **should be avoided**.



Identifying exclamations

Sentences beginning with *what* and *how* can either ask or state something, so the only way to know which punctuation mark to use is to understand what the sentence is saying and how it is being said.

What a nightmare this is?



What a nightmare this is!



This sentence is stating something, not asking something. It is an exclamation, so it requires an exclamation point rather than a question mark.

What is a nightmare?



What is a nightmare?



This sentence is asking something, not exclaiming something. It is a question, so it requires a question mark rather than an exclamation point.